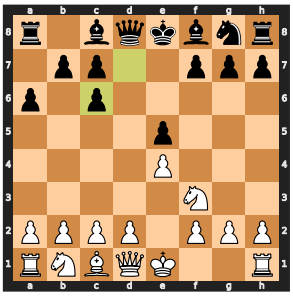
Game 11



Ruy Lopez

Capablanca – Janowski

St. Petersburg, 1914

White: J. R. Capablanca Black: D. Janowski

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♗b5 a6 4.♗xc6 dxc6 5.♘c3

I played this move after having discussed it with Alechin on several occasions. Alechin considered it, at the time, superior to 5.d4, which is generally played. He played it himself later on in the Tournament, in one of his games against Dr. E. Lasker, and obtained the superior game, which he only lost through a blunder.

5...♗c5

5...f6 is probably the best move in this position. I do not like the text move.

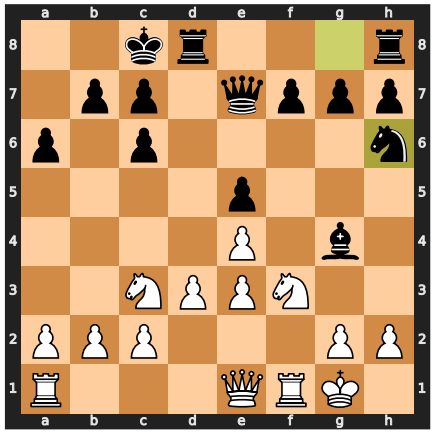
6.d3 ♗g4 7.♗e3 ♗xe3

This opens the f-file for White, and also reinforces his centre, but Black naturally did not want to make a second move with this Bishop.

8.fxe3 ♕e7 9.0–0 0–0–0

Bold play, typical of Janowski.

10.♕e1 ♘h6



The problem for White now is to advance his b-pawn to b5 as fast as he can. If he plays 11.b4 at once, Black simply takes it. If he plays first a3 and then b4, he will still have to protect his b-pawn before he can go on and play a4 and b5. As a matter of fact White played a rather unusual move, but one which, under the circumstances, was the best, since after it he could at once play b4 and then a4 and b5.

11.♖b1! f6 12.b4 ♘f7 13.a4 ♗xf3

He simplifies, hoping to lighten White's attack, which will have to be conducted practically with

only the heavy pieces on the board. He may have also done it in order to play ♘g5 and e6.

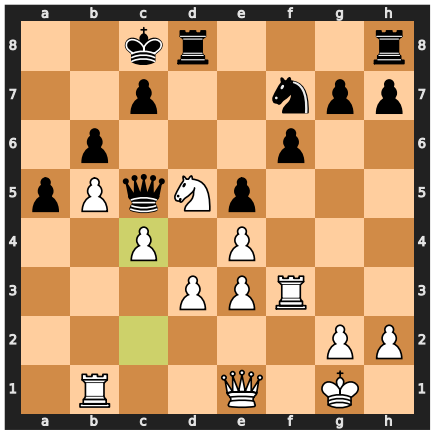
14. ♖xf3

Taking with the Pawn would have opened a possibility for a counter attack.

14...b6

He is forced to this in order to avoid the breaking up of his Queen's side Pawns. The only alternative would have been 14...b5; which on the face of it looks bad.

15.b5 cxb5 16.axb5 a5 17.♘d5 ♕c5 18.c4



The White Knight is now a tower of strength. Behind it White will be able to prepare an attack, which will begin with d4, to drive away the Black Queen and thus leave himself free to play c5. There is only one thing to take care of and that is to prevent Black from sacrificing the Rook for the Knight and a Pawn.

18...♘g5 19.♖f2 ♘e6 20.♕c3 ♖d7

Had White on his 19th move played 19.♖f1 instead of 19.♖f2, Black could have played now instead of the text move, ♖xd5; exd5, ♕xe3+; followed by ♘f4 with a winning game.

21.♖d1 ♔b7

It would have been better for Black to play 21...♔d8. The text move loses very rapidly.

22.d4 ♕d6 23.♖c2 exd4 24.exd4 ♘f4 25.c5 ♘xd5 26.exd5 ♕xd5 27.c6+ ♔b8 28.cxd7 ♕xd7 29.d5 ♖e8 30.d6 cxd6 31.♕c6 Resigns.